RESONANCE

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Resonance

Resonance is a game design framework for role-playing games in which fiction determines what enters resolution and can also determine how that resolution works.

At the same time, it provides a **fully playable standard configuration**. You do not need to design your own game in order to use Resonance.

You can simply play.

Or you can go further and make resolution resonate with a particular world, culture, cosmology, genre, trope, or perspective.

> **Resonance is complete for play and open for design.**

The useful distinction is not between a core engine and additional modules, but between three levels:

- **the invariants of Resonance**, which define the framework's fundamental gesture;
- **the standard configuration**, which provides simple, immediately playable choices;
- **design choices**, which a game can keep or transform in order to express its world.

> **Resonance defines what must be decided.**
> **The standard configuration provides a default decision.**
> **A Resonance game can keep or transform those decisions.**

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1. Discovering Resonance

A scene in a few seconds

> **GM:** The stone door is beginning to close. What do you do?
>
> **Player:** I run to get through before it shuts.
>
> **GM:** All right. What matters here?
>
> **Player:** I'm fast. And I was already running.
>
> **GM:** Yes. But the floor is covered in rubble.
>
> **Player:** And my leg is injured.
>
> **GM:** Exactly. Anything else?
>
> *Silence.*
>
> **GM:** Then let's see what happens.

That is the fundamental gesture of Resonance.

The fictional world always contains more detail than a resolution can take into account. The table selects what matters to the question at hand, puts those elements into play, resolves the uncertainty, then uses the result to transform the fiction.

Resonance therefore does not begin by asking:

> *Which value on my character sheet applies? What bonus can I add?*

It begins by asking:

> **What matters here?**

The rule does not try to replace the player's view of the scene.

It extends that view.

The resolution loop

A Resonance resolution follows a simple loop:

1. **State what you want to achieve.**
2. **Frame the question and its scale.**
3. **Make important consequences explicit when necessary.**
4. **Identify what matters to that question.**
5. **Discard what is irrelevant or redundant at that scale.**
6. **Resolve the uncertainty.**
7. **Read the form of the result.**
8. **Interpret that result from what was put into play.**
9. **Continue from the transformed world.**

This loop is the heart of Resonance. The way uncertainty is materialized or read can vary from one game to another; to learn how to play, we will begin with the **standard configuration**.

The table contract comes before the mechanics

Resonance regularly asks the table to judge what matters in the fiction. That freedom requires a shared frame.

Before play, the table should at least know:

- what world and tone it is trying to bring to life;
- what degree of danger it accepts;
- who arbitrates when there is disagreement about a Bet;
- what limits or sensitivities must be respected;
- whether some consequences should always be announced before a player exposes their character to them;

- what optional coherence or safety tools it wants to use.

The social contract does not replace the rules. It provides the context in which judgments of relevance can function without becoming a permanent negotiation.

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2. Framing a resolution

Intention: what are you actually trying to achieve?

The player begins by stating what they are trying to accomplish in the fiction.

> *I want to stop the guard from reaching the door.*

An **Intention** is not an ability, a standardized action, or a menu entry.

It is what the character is actually trying to obtain.

The same Intention can be pursued in many ways. Resonance does not first ask which rule corresponds to the action. It asks what, in the fiction, will actually bear on what the character is trying to do.

Important consequences must be visible

The word **stakes** can still be used in its ordinary sense for what may be gained, lost, or transformed, but it is not a distinct mechanical concept in Resonance.

What matters is simpler: **players should be able to know the significant consequences they are exposing themselves to when those consequences are not already obvious.**

> **Player:** I jump from the roof to the other building.
>
> **GM:** All right. At this distance, if you fall, the drop could kill you. Do you still do it?

The necessary level of precision depends on the table contract and the game being played.

The goal is not to announce everything that might happen, but to let the player make an informed decision **from their character's situation**.

Focus: what question are we resolving?

The table then clarifies the question the resolution is meant to answer.

> *Do you manage to stop the guard before they raise the alarm?*

That question defines the **Focus**.

The Focus does not describe everything happening in the scene. It determines **what this resolution is looking at**.

Not everything on the character sheet is necessarily relevant.

Not everything in the world is necessarily relevant.

Even something important to the story may not matter to this particular resolution.

Zoom: at what scale?

The Focus has a scale. Resonance calls this property the **Zoom**.

> **The Focus says what we are resolving.**
> **The Zoom says at what scale we are resolving it.**

Choosing the Focus therefore also means choosing how broad a question we are asking of the fiction.

Action Zoom

The Focus concerns a single act or precise moment.

> *Get through the door before it closes.*

The space of Bets is naturally restricted. Several formulations of the same advantage tend to be redundant because the resolution is looking at a narrow instant.

Sequence Zoom

The Focus concerns a coherent succession of actions.

> *Cross the rooftops and lose the guards before reaching the temple.*

Elements that would have been redundant in a single action can become distinct because they concern different dimensions or stages of the sequence: endurance, knowledge of the neighborhood, help from an accomplice, rain making the tiles slippery, fear of being recognized.

Script Zoom

The Focus covers a broader whole: a journey, investigation, military campaign, prolonged negotiation, or complex project.

> *Get a caravan through to the besieged city.*

The character or group can then bring several genuinely distinct dimensions into play: relationships, logistics, reputation, knowledge, endurance, wealth, political protection, preparation, or sacrifice.

These are not "more bonuses because the conflict lasts longer."

They are more relevant dimensions because the question being asked is broader.

Zoom therefore lets the table control pacing without inventing a subsystem for every type of scene.

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3. Putting fiction in the balance

The character sheet: a memory of fiction

Resonance uses a character sheet, but it is not organized around levels, classes, or numerical values to be increased.

It is primarily **literary and meaningful**: keywords, relationships, states, objects, affiliations, convictions, symbols, injuries, oaths, reputations, or other elements specific to the game world.

For example:

- *Veteran of the Northern War*;
- *Oath to the Red House*;
- *Injured leg*;
- a religious symbol;
- the name of an ally or rival;
- a Rune, title, debt, or mark that matters to the game.

The sheet is one of the persistent memories of what is true about the character.

It is neither the only source of Bets nor a catalogue of automatic bonuses.

> **Reading your sheet is not about looking for what gives you a die.**
> **It is about remembering who the character is and what is true about them.**

A keyword on the sheet can be perfectly true without being relevant to the current Focus.

Conversely, a decisive truth in the scene can become a Bet even if it has never been written on any sheet.

The character's relevance space

The sheet also describes part of the character's current **relevance space**: the lasting truths that constitute them and that the fiction may eventually make relevant.

This space is neither a power level nor a list of activatable abilities.

It describes what the character has become: what they know, what they believe, what they belong to, what they love or hate, what they carry, what they have suffered, the ties that bind them, and the symbols that mean something to them.

A young warrior might begin with:

> *Clan — Master — Duty — Reputation — Obedience*

Then their story might bring forth:

> *Compassion — Personal love — Doubt — Truth — Refusal of an unjust order*

Some truths are added. Others disappear. Others are transformed:

> *Obedient to my master → Doubtful of my master → Betrayed by my master*

The character has not necessarily gained an ability.

Their relevance space has changed.

This is how Resonance approaches progression: not as an intrinsic numerical climb, but as a transformation of the truths that can matter.

> **To progress in Resonance is to transform what can matter.**

Bets

The elements the table decides matter become **Bets**.

> **A Bet is a fictional truth that the game and the table make relevant to the current Focus.**

A Bet exists in the fiction before it exists in the mechanics.

It can come, among other things, from:

- the character or their sheet: experience, ability, state, reputation, fear, conviction;
- their relationships: ally, debt, rivalry, oath, love, loyalty;
- the situation: position, preparation, surprise, urgency;
- the environment: rain, darkness, terrain, crowd, fire;
- the adversity: weakness, advantage, discipline, numbers, knowledge;
- the world: custom, taboo, status, magic, cosmology, or a particular constraint;
- anything else the game and situation make genuinely significant.

This list is not exhaustive.

A Bet is therefore not an abstract bonus attached to the character.

But not everything that is true in the fiction automatically becomes a Bet.

The question is not:

Can I find a justification for adding this?

The question is:

Does this genuinely matter to the resolution we are looking at?

The movement can be summarized as follows:

Fiction proposes. Focus selects. The Bet makes it operative.

A Bet can help or hinder

A Bet is not necessarily favorable to the character who brings it up.

I know this forest perfectly.

may work in their favor.

My leg is injured.

may work against them.

But their relevance always depends on the Focus **and on the game the table is trying to bring to life**.

An injury may be central in a game that constantly foregrounds physical vulnerability and remain in the background in another game that is more concerned with political drama or relationships.

A Bet is therefore not "objectively important" in the abstract.

It becomes important here, in this game, for this resolution.

A Bet is also a choice of attention

Relevance is not only causal.

In fiction, we never pay equal attention to every possible detail. The game, the scene, and the table bring some things to the foreground.

The mischievous look of an old sage may matter because the story has taught us to recognize their wisdom in it.

The storm around a duel may matter because this game gives special importance to signs from the world.

The imminent arrival of an enemy may matter because the entire scene is shaped by that urgency.

A character's legendary clumsiness may matter because it has become a motif of the fiction.

The participants do not merely observe what would be causally important.

They also choose what this fiction deserves to focus on right now.

That selection is not arbitrary: it is guided by the world, genre, tropes, rules of the game, and what the table has learned to treat as meaningful.

Relevance and non-redundancy

A rich world almost always lets us formulate several closely related reasons for the same advantage.

I am an excellent swordsman.
I have trained since childhood.
I am a veteran of three wars.

All three facts may be true without constituting three distinct Bets.

The question is:

At the scale of this Focus, do they really represent several different things that the resolution wants to put into play?

If all three formulations simply mean "they are very experienced with a sword" in an exchange lasting a few seconds, they are probably redundant.

In a broader resolution, they could instead become distinct if they genuinely affect different dimensions of the situation.

Non-redundancy is therefore not an accounting rule.

It depends on the Focus and its Zoom.

Closing the Bets

The table does not need to find everything that could theoretically matter.

In a rich world, that search would never end.

The criterion is simpler:

When nobody immediately sees anything else that matters and does not repeat what has already been established, resolve.

A Bet should not be the result of exhaustively searching the character sheet, the lore, or the scene.

You do not search for a Bet. You notice it.

The table ritual can remain extremely light:

What matters here?
Anything else?
Silence.
Then let's see what happens.

The conversation exists to make the situation clear enough to resolve, not to maximize a pool.

Opposition and counter-Bets

A Bet can naturally reveal a truth that favors the other side.

> **Player:** I'm already between him and the door.
>
> **GM:** He knows this barracks perfectly.
>
> **Player:** Exactly. He has to get around me in this narrow corridor.
>
> **GM:** But two soldiers are coming up behind you.

This conversation is not a negotiation over bonuses. It gradually reveals the different elements the fiction makes relevant.

This is also why oppositions can tend to balance organically: looking at a situation more closely often reveals new elements for several sides.

That does not mean every opposition should be balanced.

A real fictional advantage should remain a real fictional advantage.

Counter-Bets are an **organic counterweight** produced by exploring the fiction, not a mathematical obligation to make every pool equal.

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4. Resolving and interpreting

The standard configuration

Resonance's standard configuration lets you play immediately with six-sided dice.

For each side:

- each retained Bet contributes **one D6** to its pool;
- each **even** result counts as a **Success**;
- each **odd** result produces no Success;
- the number of Successes obtained is then compared.

This operation turns uncertainty into a comparable mechanical signal: a number of Successes.

> **Bets → D6 → even / odd → Successes → comparison → interpretation through the Bets**

The standard result scale

Tie: Status quo or escalation

If both sides obtain the same number of Successes, neither side clearly prevails.

The standard result is a **Status quo**.

Depending on the fiction, it can be narrated as a literal continuation of the situation, a **Yes, but...** or a **No, but...**.

If the sides refuse to leave it there, the standard configuration also allows **escalation**:

- keep the Bets already in play;
- each side adds a Bet representing its **determination to finish this**;
- resolve again with the enlarged pools.

Escalation makes mechanically present the fact that the sides choose to push a confrontation beyond a balance at which it could have stopped.

A game designed with Resonance can choose another philosophy for ties. What matters is that it knows what a tie means in its own fiction.

Positive difference: Victory / Defeat

If one side obtains more Successes than the other, it gains a **Victory** and the other side suffers a **Defeat**.

For the winning side's Intention, this usually reads as **Yes**.

For the losing side's Intention, this usually reads as **No**.

Dominance: amplifying the result

In the standard configuration, a result is **dominated** when both of the following conditions are met:

1. the difference is **strictly greater than 1 Success**;
2. the winning side obtains **strictly more than twice** as many Successes as the losing side.

Examples:

- `2-0` → dominated result;
- `3-1` → dominated result;
- `4-2` → simple Victory / Defeat;
- `5-2` → dominated result;
- `6-3` → simple Victory / Defeat.

Dominance expresses a **strong asymmetry in the result**, not merely a large absolute difference.

It opens the possibility of fictional amplification:

- the winning side may achieve an **Exploit**, read as **Yes, and...**;
- the losing side may suffer a **Fiasco**, read as **No, and...**.

Exploit and Fiasco are not automatically symmetrical.

A spectacular success for one side does not necessarily turn the other side's failure into a catastrophe. Conversely, a Defeat may have particularly serious consequences without the victor accomplishing anything beyond their own Intention.

Dominance indicates that amplification is available; the fiction determines what it means for each side.

Interpreting: the Bets return to the fiction

Bets do not merely build the pool before the roll.

They also provide the material for interpretation after the roll.

Once the result is known, the table already has:

- the Intention;
- the Focus and its Zoom;
- any important consequences that were announced;
- what mattered in the fiction;
- the direction given by the resolution.

There is therefore no need to invent an arbitrary consequence from an abstract number.

Imagine a mountain crossing in which the Bets are:

- *the driving rain*;
- *the fear that the pursuers will arrive*;
- *the character's experience with mountain passes*;
- *their companion's trust*.

On a Defeat, the rain may make the pass impassable, urgency may cause a bad decision, experience may prevent a worse consequence, or the companion may stay behind so the others can continue.

The dice provide a direction.

The Bets give the table the material through which that direction becomes fiction.

The words **Yes**, **No**, **And**, and **But** are a practical vocabulary for interpretation. They are not mechanics unique to Resonance.

When resolution writes on the character sheet

A lasting consequence can add, transform, or remove an element of the sheet when the fiction justifies it.

For example:

- *Injured leg* may appear after a serious fall;
- *Companion's trust* may become *Companion's mistrust*;

- an oath may be broken or replaced;
- a reputation may be earned;
- an object, symbol, or mark may be lost;
- a new truth may appear as a consequence of an **And** or a **But**.

The sheet therefore does not merely recall what could matter before the roll.

It can also preserve what resolution has changed.

This writing does not need to be systematic. Many consequences remain local to the scene or the world.

But when a change becomes lasting and is now part of what the character is, owns, believes, suffers, or represents, the sheet can become its memory.

The full loop then becomes:

> **fiction / sheet → Intention → Focus / Zoom → Bets → resolution → direction → interpretation → transformed fiction / sheet**

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5. What maintains coherence

At first glance, Resonance may seem dangerously permissive: if almost any fictional truth can become a Bet, why couldn't the table simply invoke everything until the pools grow without limit?

The answer is not one single mechanism.

Resonance relies on **several layers of coherence that act at different points**:

1. **The table contract** defines how the group plays together and what authority is entrusted to each participant.
2. **The grammar of relevance** indicates the families of meaning toward which the game directs the table's attention.
3. **Frame Factors** close off some possibilities.
4. **The Focus and its Zoom** determine what the resolution is looking at here and now.
5. **Relevance and non-redundancy** determine what can actually become a distinct Bet.
6. **Opposition and counter-Bets** reveal the counterweights already present in the fiction.
7. **The Fate Gauge**, when used, remembers the imbalances that persist across successive oppositions.

These tools do not perform the same job and should not be confused with one another.

Frame Factors: what closes the space of possibilities

The Focus selects what matters, but it cannot abolish fundamental constraints of the world or situation.

A **Frame Factor** expresses a proposition strong enough to alter the very space of possible Intentions, available means, or admissible Bets.

It does not provide a bonus or penalty.

It closes a possibility or makes a means inadmissible until the fiction changes.

World-level Frame Factor

> *Time travel does not exist in this world.*

This is not a very difficult action. It simply does not belong to the normal space of possibilities.

Structural Frame Factor

> *You cannot kill a dragon with a toothpick simply by accumulating relevant Bets.*

The problem is not the size of the pool. The proposed means does not allow this resolution to be opened in that form.

Local Frame Factor

> *This reception requires formal dress. In shorts, you are not getting through the front door.*

The character can change plans, find another entrance, acquire suitable clothing, or transform the situation.

A Frame Factor therefore does not necessarily block play.

It requires the fiction to change before some Intentions or means become admissible.

The grammar of relevance: what the game teaches you to notice

The grammar of relevance moves almost in the opposite direction.

It does not close the space of possibilities. It indicates **where the game directs attention so that the table can discover truths likely to become Bets**.

It can take the form of nested semantic families.

For example:

> **Relationships**
> → oaths, debts, loves, rivalries
> → specific people or bonds
> → currently relevant truths
> → possible Bets

Or:

Cultural identity
→ belonging, customs, taboos, values, symbols
→ specific keywords of the character and world
→ elements the Focus may make relevant

A character sheet can materialize part of that grammar.

But the grammar is broader than the sheet: it also exists in lore, non-player characters, institutions, places, magic, tropes, and genre conventions.

It is not an exhaustive list of allowed Bets.

It is an organization of attention.

Adjudicating a Bet

The table shares responsibility for bringing forth what matters, but it must know how to decide when there is disagreement.

In a classic configuration:

- players propose the elements they see as relevant;
- the GM embodies adversity and the world;
- the table tests those proposals against the Focus, Zoom, Frame Factors, and the game's grammar;
- the GM makes the final call if the table contract gives them that responsibility.

That validation should not rest on the adjudicator's personal preference alone.

> **A good adjudicator is not the person who decides whatever suits them. A good adjudicator maintains the coherence of the world, the game, and the shared Focus.**

The Fate Gauge: remembering imbalances

Oppositions do not need to be balanced one by one.

A character who is genuinely advantaged in the fiction should benefit from that advantage.

For tables that nevertheless want to keep track of successive imbalances, Resonance offers an optional **Fate Gauge** shared by the group.

It can be represented by:

- **blue** dice in favor of the protagonists;
- **red** dice in favor of adversity.

Before the roll, if the pools are unequal, the difference feeds the Gauge in favor of the side currently at a disadvantage.

> The protagonists have 5 Bets and adversity has 3.
> The opposition remains **5 versus 3**.
> The Gauge receives **2 red dice**.

Later:

> The protagonists have 2 Bets and adversity has 5.
> The Gauge should receive **3 blue dice**.
> One blue die and one red die cancel first: if 1 red die remained, the Gauge now contains 2 blue dice.

The Gauge therefore does not immediately correct each imbalance.

It preserves a mechanical memory of the way the fiction has leaned.

Available dice can be spent later according to the authority agreed upon by the table. In a configuration where the GM controls adversity, for example, they can draw on red dice to strengthen a future opposition.

They do not have to spend them on the next obstacle, nor use them automatically.

The Gauge is particularly useful for a table that wants a visible safety net. A table sufficiently confident in its adjudication can choose not to use it.

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6. Varying and designing Resonance

The standard configuration is enough to play.

But Resonance was designed for another possibility: when a world has a sufficiently strong logic, **the mechanics can stop being generic and start expressing it**.

Invariants and design choices

The following elements constitute the gesture of Resonance:

- begin from a fictional Intention;
- define a Focus and its Zoom;
- make important consequences visible when the table contract requires it;
- select what matters;
- avoid redundancy at the chosen scale;
- confront the Bets with some form of uncertainty;
- produce a form of result that fiction can use;
- interpret that result from the fiction that was put into play;
- begin again from the transformed world.

Other elements belong to the standard configuration and can be transformed:

- using D6s;
- associating one Bet with one die;
- reading even numbers as Successes;

- opposing two pools;
- using the same physical representation for every Bet;
- using the standard result scale;
- using escalation;
- using the Fate Gauge.

Variation is not something added from outside the framework.
It is part of its design.

A standard chain of responsibilities

In the standard configuration — and in implementations that oppose sides — the operations can be separated as follows:

> **Bets → uncertainty medium → Prism → mechanical signals → result scale → interpretation → transformed fiction**

In the standard configuration:

> **Bets → D6 → even / odd → Successes → comparison → interpretation through the Bets**

This separation avoids asking a single mechanic to do everything.
The **Prism** transforms uncertainty into mechanical signals.
The **result scale** then transforms those signals into a direction.
Interpretation finally transforms that direction into fiction from the Bets and the situation.
This chain is a reference architecture, not a universal obligation. A light implementation can use a Prism whose result is directly usable without passing through an opposition between two pools.

Prisms: how a perspective transforms uncertainty

Resonance calls a **Prism**:

> **the logic by which a perspective on the world transforms uncertainty into a result the game can use mechanically.**

In opposed-pool implementations, this often means producing **Successes** or other comparable signals.
A Prism is therefore not simply “counting the dice differently” to create an aesthetic variation.
It can modify:

- which results count;

- which patterns become meaningful;
- which dice can be rerolled or transformed;
- which results cancel one another;
- what costs are attached to certain results;
- relationships between several pools;
- the media being used;
- the very form of the result.

The concrete mechanism is the expression of a more fundamental question:

What does uncertainty mean from this way of inhabiting the world?

The standard Prism

The standard configuration has a Prism too.

The **standard Prism** treats every D6 identically: even, it produces a Success; odd, it does not.

It does not claim to represent the "true" structure of chance.

It simply provides a discreet reading when the game does not want perspective itself to become a particular mechanical issue.

It is a **design zero point**, not a norm that other Prisms should resemble.

Common outputs for different perspectives

When several Prisms need to coexist in the same opposition, the game benefits from defining a common interface.

In current opposed-pool implementations, that interface is generally the **Success**: each Prism produces Successes according to its own logic, then the result scale compares the sides.

This common output is an interoperability contract for games that need one.

It neither defines the Prism nor is mandatory for every Resonance implementation.

When should you create another Prism?

A particular Prism becomes relevant when changing resolution lets the player feel something that description alone would convey less effectively.

A game might want:

- divine favor to transform some failures;
- spirits to make patterns or repetitions meaningful;
- a logical discipline to aggregate results rather than count them;
- a mystical path to cancel an apparently secured Success;
- cyclical thought to make forms emerge rather than independent successes.

The right design question is therefore not:

What original mechanic can I invent?

but:

What relationship to the world genuinely deserves to transform the way uncertainty is experienced?

Designing a Prism

1. Begin with a relationship to the world

Before choosing a mechanic, identify the logic the game wants to make perceptible: accumulation, transcendence, intervention, balance, sacrifice, contamination, reciprocity, prediction, symbiosis, determinism, chance, or something else.

What logic of reality should become perceptible when the player resolves uncertainty?

2. Ask what the player should feel or notice

A good Prism does not merely represent an idea.

It influences what the player hopes for, fears, watches, or seeks during resolution.

Does playing this Prism push the player to look at the world the way their character does?

3. Translate that relationship into a mechanical operation

Only then choose what can make that logic perceptible:

- even or odd results;
- sums;
- patterns;
- cancellations;
- rerolls;
- die sizes;
- cards, colors, or symbols;
- interactions between pools;
- changes to adversity;
- another uncertainty medium.

The medium comes after the meaning it is meant to produce.

4. Decide what form of result to produce

If several Prisms must take part in the same opposition, a common output such as Successes may be desirable.

But a light game can use a standalone result if that better serves the intended experience.

5. Check that the mechanic is not merely decorated with lore

A Prism is not “6s explode because that is fun.”

Sixes explode if that property expresses something about the reality lived by the character and produces the intended experience at the table.

A useful test is to mentally remove the theme: if the mechanic could be arbitrarily reskinned without losing anything in how it feels, the link between Prism and fiction probably needs to be strengthened.

The mechanic is not decorated by the lore: it becomes an operation of the lore.

6. Check its cognitive cost

A Prism can be strange without becoming opaque.

The goal is not to move attention away from complex modifiers only to replace them with another equally intrusive form of technical manipulation.

Ideally, the Prism should make its perspective more perceptible than its procedure is cumbersome.

The media can resonate too

A Bet does not have to be represented by a D6 identical to every other one.

A game can use:

- dice of different sizes;
- colors with fictional meaning;
- cards;
- tokens;
- coins;
- stones or beads;
- particular objects;
- any other medium whose manipulation serves the intended experience.

Changing the medium is not interesting in itself.

The medium becomes relevant when it extends something the character or world already makes the player feel.

The goal remains the same:

reduce the distance between what the player manipulates and what their character experiences.

Designing relevance

Prisms are only one of Resonance's design points.

A game must also decide which families of fictional truths it wants to make visible and naturally available to the table's attention.

This **grammar of relevance** can be organized around:

- cultures of the world;
- magic;
- social relationships;
- institutions;
- character states;
- genre motifs;
- tropes;
- consequences accumulated in the fiction.

The grammar resembles a **semantic map** more than a closed list.

Two games can use exactly the same Prism and still produce very different experiences because they do not teach the table to look at the same things.

Designing a Resonance game therefore does not consist only of writing a random procedure.

It means deciding what the game teaches players to notice.

Trope and relevance

A game can produce a genre not only by giving mechanical structure to certain actions, but also by giving particular importance to the **reasons** that can weigh in the fiction.

Powered by the Apocalypse games provide a useful point of comparison.

Many PbtA games bring forth their genre by giving privileged mechanical structure to particular fictional triggers, consequences, Playbooks, or archetypes.

Resonance can act at another level: it can leave the space of actions broadly open while orienting the families of truths the game teaches players to treat as significant.

The trope can then emerge because the game teaches the player **what to look at, what relationships to recognize, and what reasons to let carry weight** in their own actions.

This difference does not mean that Resonance is "freer" than PbtA in every circumstance. It points to a different design lever:

orient what matters without necessarily prescribing what the character should attempt.

Designing character evolution

Because evolution happens through persistent truths, designing progression in a Resonance game does not mean drawing a level curve.

The game designer should instead decide:

- which families of truths can appear on the sheet;
- how an experience can create a new one;
- when a truth can be reworded, replaced, or removed;
- who has authority to write those transformations;
- which changes require a resolution and which simply follow from an established fictional event;
- how the game makes important transformations visible.

> **The grammar of relevance defines the possible language of evolution.**
> **The character's story progressively writes their relevance space in that language.**

Two characters who began with similar sheets can therefore diverge dramatically without either one being "higher level" than the other.

Three levels not to confuse

Resonance

The framework.

It provides the general grammar of resolution, its concepts, and its points of variation.

The standard configuration

A fully playable reference implementation.

It lets you use Resonance immediately without any prior game design work.

A game designed with Resonance

An implementation that chooses what to keep and what to transform in order to produce an experience specific to its world.

It can define, among other things:

- its grammar of relevance;
- the form of its sheets and fictional memories;
- its Prisms;
- its Frame Factors;
- its media;
- its game economies;

- how its characters evolve;
- its coherence or regulation tools;
- how it interprets consequences.

A design checklist

When designing a game with Resonance, ask in particular:

1. **What does this world or genre teach players to notice?**
2. **Which families of truths should be especially visible?**
3. **How do the sheet, lore, or other media make these truths memorable without turning them into automatic bonuses?**
4. **What makes two Bets distinct or redundant?**
5. **Which Frame Factors genuinely close off possibilities?**
6. **Which consequences must be explicit before a player exposes themselves to them?**
7. **Is the standard configuration enough to express this world?**
8. **If not, what perspective deserves a particular Prism?**
9. **What should that Prism make the player feel rather than merely simulate?**
10. **Does the game need opposed pools and a common output?**
11. **Would another medium than a D6 make the experience more direct?**
12. **Which consequences should return durably to the fiction or the sheet?**
13. **How can the character's truths appear, transform, and disappear?**
14. **What mechanisms maintain coherence when the table interprets relevance freely?**
15. **What safeguards prevent the search for Bets from becoming mechanical optimization again?**

Every variation should be able to answer one simple question:

> **What does this rule let the player perceive, understand, or feel about the world?**

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7. Understanding Resonance

The concepts below describe different aspects of the same framework. They are not prerequisites for play.

Cognitive: where does the player's attention go?

Resonance can be described as **cognitive** because its central operation is less about calculating a character value than about making a judgment of relevance about a fictional situation.

The player observes the scene, remembers what their character knows and has lived through, perhaps rereads the keywords or symbols on their sheet, pays attention to relationships, environment, and circumstances, then identifies what matters.

The technical load can therefore remain low even while the fiction remains rich.

The term “cognitive” primarily describes **the mental interface between player, character, and world**.

The goal is not to eliminate thought.

It is to direct thought toward the fiction rather than toward manipulating an abstract model.

Diegetic: where do mechanical elements come from?

Resonance can be described as **diegetic** when the elements manipulated by the rules remain attached to things that already have meaning in the fiction.

An injury, oath, wind, reputation, or relationship is not first a modifier.

It exists in the fictional world, then becomes mechanically present because it matters.

This continuity can also concern the media being used: colors, dice, cards, or objects can extend a meaning already experienced in the fiction.

> **The diegetic concerns continuity between what exists in the world and what the rules manipulate.**

Perspectival: who is looking at reality?

Perspectivism adds another possibility.

A diegetic design can give mechanical weight to what exists in the fiction while keeping the same procedure for every character.

A perspectival design accepts that the same reality may produce a different resolution depending on how it is lived, understood, or inhabited.

The point of view is no longer only narrated.

It becomes mechanically operative.

This is one of the things Prisms can do when they are tied to different ways of entering into relationship with the world.

> **Diegetic: what exists in the fiction can become mechanical.**
> **Perspectival: the way the fiction is lived can transform the mechanics.**

Ontological: what reality do the mechanics assert?

The term **ontological** becomes relevant when a game does not merely represent several subjective interpretations of an assumed neutral reality, but treats those relationships to reality as genuinely different ways in which the world exists or acts.

The mechanics then no longer say only:

this character understands the world this way.

They can go as far as saying:

within this relationship to reality, the world actually works this way.

This distinction is especially important in worlds where several cosmologies or modes of existence are simultaneously true without being reducible to a single underlying mechanical model.

You can therefore have:

- a diegetic game without perspectivism;
- a perspectival game without a strong ontological commitment;
- a game in which perspective and ontology are deeply intertwined.

These terms describe design possibilities. They are not mandatory labels for using Resonance.

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8. Resonance in practice: two bounds of the design space

The first two Resonance case studies deliberately occupy very different positions.

Glorantha Perspectives tests depth: a dense world, several cosmologies, different relationships to reality, and a strong continuity between lore and mechanics.

Resonance: Scooby-Doo tests compression: an immediately recognizable trope, character creation in a handful of keywords, strongly characterized Prisms, and minimal infrastructure.

Together, they provide two useful bounds for the design space.

Glorantha Perspectives — the depth test

Glorantha Perspectives is a complete implementation of Resonance.

In that implementation, Prisms are called **worldviews**, using terminology specific to Glorantha. It is the same design concept; only the implementation's vocabulary changes.

Glorantha is particularly well suited to Resonance because its cosmologies are not merely decorative opinions laid over a single mechanical physics.

The way a character inhabits the world can change how that world becomes mechanically accessible.

Theism

Even numbers are Successes.

Sixes can produce extraordinary effects and give some normally failed results another possibility.

Faith transforms the meaning of failure.

Animism

Even numbers are Successes.

Patterns among dice that would normally fail can become meaningful.

The world remains populated by relationships and presences even within what seemed to produce nothing.

Logic

Dice are no longer read as independent successes.

Their values are aggregated according to a calculation rule.

Uncertainty becomes calculation.

Mysticism

Some results can cancel an opponent's apparent Successes.

Material victory can become secondary to a deeper reality.

Draconic Thought

Bets use D8s, and particular patterns can create choices between material accomplishment and spiritual transformation.

The result itself brings forth a tension proper to Draconic thought.

Going beyond a list of Prisms

Lunar influence can change the way some Prisms are experienced.

Illumination can become a transformation genuinely lived by the player through the mechanics.

Heroquests can go as far as allowing characters to seek, discover, or create a new way of understanding reality.

At that point, the mechanics no longer merely illustrate the lore.

They let the player think through it.

Glorantha Perspectives shows how:

- a grammar of relevance can emerge from a very dense world;
- several Prisms can make different relationships to reality mechanically operative;
- Frame Factors can express cosmological, social, or cultural truths;
- an economy such as the Fate Gauge can act as a safety net;
- lore can become material for play rather than a corpus consulted beside the rules.

> **The system does not merely describe the world. It lets the player experience the world through its own logic.**

Read Glorantha Perspectives →

Resonance: Scooby-Doo — the compression test

At the other extreme, **Resonance: Scooby-Doo** shows how far the framework can be compressed without losing its central idea.

The design material is not an encyclopedic cosmology, but an immediately recognizable trope: a group of young people, a van, a monster that is probably fake, an absurd investigation, and a chase that descends into chaos.

Character creation through keywords

Players choose an archetype and a few keywords that make it immediately playable.

For example:

- **The Handsome Guy with the terrible plan**: natural authority, obsession with elaborate traps, "let's split up," wildly disproportionate confidence in his own ideas;
- **The Brain**: absolute skepticism, walking encyclopedia, severe myopia, relentless deduction;
- **The Pretty Airhead**: danger-prone, piercing scream, improbable handbag, ability to discover important things by accident;
- **The Clumsy Duo**: hunger, fear, flight, shared language, and an almost supernatural ability to produce chaos.

Even the **Van** has a small shared sheet: psychedelic paint, temperamental engine, secret snack reserve, dubious equipment, or any other truth likely to return in the fiction.

This creation process directly illustrates Resonance's literary character sheet: keywords do not define what the character is allowed to do; they give the player memorable material that may become relevant.

Trope as a grammar of relevance

The game naturally makes the following visible:

- fear;
- appetite;
- clues;
- overcomplicated plans;
- splitting up the group;
- absurd coincidences;
- the mask behind the monster;
- each team member's relationships and gimmicks.

Players remain free to attempt whatever they want, but the game quickly teaches them what kinds of reasons belong to this fiction.

The Clumsy Duo: a standalone result

Shaggy and Scooby do not necessarily play against an opposing pool.

Each gathers their own Bets and rolls a separate pool.

Their even results count normally and their Successes are added together.

But their bond has an additional mechanical translation:

> **each cross-pair of matching odd results between their two rolls produces one additional Success.**

A 3 rolled by Shaggy does not resonate with another 3 rolled by Shaggy. A 3 must also appear in Scooby's roll.

They remain two characters with two distinct pools, but their clumsiness becomes more effective when they are together.

The rule therefore pushes them mechanically toward their trope: **Shaggy and Scooby benefit from staying side by side.**

The result directly describes **the scale of the chaos they produce**.

This case shows that a Prism can produce a **standalone result**: Resonance does not force every implementation through "two pools → comparable Successes → opposition."

The Brain: the most conventional logic

The Brain instead uses an opposition close to the standard configuration.

She searches for clues, confronts hypotheses with the world, and gets a resolution that reads in an almost rational way.

The contrast with the other characters is part of her identity.

The Handsome Guy: misalignment

His Prism makes his plans resonate sideways.

A plan can work exactly as intended but on the wrong target; an apparent failure can accidentally trigger the mechanism that actually captures the monster.

The design goal is also to make his tendency to split up the group mechanically attractive: the trope should not merely be narrated, it should create an incentive in play.

The Pretty Airhead: meaningful accident

She can look for patterns, sequences, or particular correspondences instead of merely maximizing Successes.

A pattern can trigger an "Oops": she leans on a bookshelf and opens a secret passage, presses the wrong button and shuts down the force field, or accidentally draws the monster's attention at the perfect moment.

The game therefore teaches her player to seek a particular form of chance that is coherent with her trope.

Why this implementation matters

Scooby-Doo demonstrates that Resonance can work when:

- the lore fits into a few paragraphs;
- character creation takes a few minutes;
- keywords are deliberately comic;
- Prisms are asymmetric;
- some results are standalone;
- fidelity is about rhythm and trope more than complex cosmology.

Glorantha tests how far Resonance can **descend into the depth of a world**.

Scooby-Doo tests how far it can **rise toward simplicity without becoming generic**.

The space between them remains open.

Read Resonance: Scooby-Doo →

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9. Prism Workshop

This section is **not** a list of recommended rules or a catalogue of official Prisms.

It is a **game design workshop**.

The proposals below are deliberately experimental. Their purpose is to explore what Resonance makes it possible to think about when we take seriously the idea that a relationship to the world can transform resolution itself.

The right way to use this workshop is therefore not:

> *Which Prism should I copy?*

but:

> **What does this example teach me about the design space?**

Transforming the relationship to prediction and probability

Prophecy — Commitment

Before rolling, the player announces the exact number of Successes they expect to obtain.

Getting the prediction exactly right produces an exceptional result; missing it turns the test into a failure or strong consequence depending on the game.

The player may be encouraged to **voluntarily reduce the number of Bets** they commit in order to make their own prophecy more credible.

The game thus turns supposed knowledge of the future into present behavior.

Possible diegetic expressions: oracle, prescience, a calculator able to commit to a prediction.

Balance — Duality

The player divides their Bets into two distinct sets.

The quality of the result depends less on the raw total than on the proximity between the two sets: balance becomes mechanically desirable.

Possible diegetic expressions: philosophy of the mean, complementary elemental forces, Yin-Yang discipline, balance between two natures of the character.

Transforming the relationship to adversity

Symbiosis — Mimicry

A player's die becomes a Success only if it shows exactly the same value as a die in the adversity pool.

You therefore do not win by simply producing more independent successes.

You win by finding **a form of correspondence with what you are facing**.

Possible diegetic expressions: telepathy, absolute diplomacy, assimilation, neural hacking, magic based on attunement or copying.

Parasite — Corruption

Some low results allow the player to take, move, or exchange elements of the opposing pool.

The character's strength then literally comes from what they steal from the other side.

Possible diegetic expressions: necromancy, corruption, curse, parasitic organism.

Transforming the nature of the medium

Weaver — Cards

Each Bet lets the player draw a card instead of rolling a die.

Combinations — pairs, runs, suits, or colors — produce Successes or additional information.

The medium itself becomes part of the perspective.

Ascension — variable dice

Bets can justify dice of different sizes.

An important result may depend not only on high values but on the ability to make a progression appear across several die sizes.

The character is no longer merely trying to "roll high": they are trying to produce a form of transcendence.

Transforming the relationship to solitude

Isolation — Singularity

The presence of allies reduces the character's power or disturbs the way they act.

One version might remove a die or neutralize a Success for each directly involved ally.

Conversely, when the character acts entirely alone, some failed results could be rerolled or transformed.

Possible diegetic expressions: cursed berserker, assassin whose magic requires solitude, keeper of a secret who loses power in the presence of a witness.

This kind of Prism can shape **the very composition of the scenes the player prefers to seek out**.

Transforming the relationship to the group

Synergy — Gestalt

Success cannot be entirely individual.

In a simple version, a Success exists only when one of the character's dice finds exactly the same value in an ally's roll.

In another, every ally present lets the character turn one category of failure into a Success or opens an additional pattern.

Possible diegetic expressions: collective consciousness, telepathic twins, networked artificial intelligences, military phalanx, magical choir.

Transforming collaboration into toxic dependence

Parasitic Prisms — Dependence

Collaboration exists, but it is asymmetric: one character benefits by taking something away from the others.

They may gain extra Successes by taking dice from allies' pools, or protect their own Defeat by destroying a nearby ally's Success.

Possible diegetic expressions: psychic vampire, necromancer, toxic leader, noble whose status protects them at the expense of their servants.

Here, the Prism does not merely simulate an unpleasant personality.

It makes the group mechanically feel **the toxic relational structure** the character imposes on it.

What the Workshop is trying to show

These prototypes do not claim to be balanced against one another or even compatible within the same game.

They explore several directions:

- transforming probability;
- transforming what the player looks for in a roll;
- transforming the relationship to adversity;
- transforming the relationship to allies;
- transforming the desired composition of a scene;
- transforming the medium;
- transforming the form of the result itself;
- producing, when it serves the game, a standalone result without an opposing pool.

The Workshop does not define Resonance's limits. It helps search for them.

In summary

Resonance organizes a simple movement:

> **Start from fiction, determine what matters, confront those truths with uncertainty, then return to transformed fiction.**

A resolution begins with an **Intention**. The **Focus** specifies the question and its **Zoom** the scale at which it is viewed. The **grammar of relevance** teaches the table which families of truths deserve its attention; **Frame Factors** close off what does not belong to the space of possibilities. Among everything that is true of the character, their relationships, the situation, and the world, the elements that are genuinely relevant and non-redundant become **Bets**.

Fiction proposes. Focus selects. The Bet makes it operative.

The Bets are then confronted with uncertainty.

In the standard configuration, each Bet contributes a D6, even results produce Successes, and the sides can compare their results. This procedure is enough to play immediately, but it is not the identity of the framework: it is a default answer to the decisions every Resonance implementation must make.

When a perspective deserves to become mechanically operative, a **Prism** can transform the way uncertainty is read. The medium, the patterns being sought, interactions between pools, or even the form of the result can then express a particular relationship to the world.

The Prism transforms uncertainty. The result provides a direction. The Bets give that direction a fictional form.

Resolution does not stop at the result. Its interpretation returns to the world. Some consequences remain local; others become persistent truths, written on the sheet or elsewhere in the fiction. They may in turn become relevant in a future resolution.

What happens today transforms what can matter tomorrow.

The complete loop can therefore be read as:

fiction / sheet → Intention → Focus / Zoom → Bets → uncertainty / Prism → result → interpretation → transformed fiction / sheet

The exact mechanism at the center of this loop can change. The movement itself does not. The framework therefore distinguishes three levels:

- **Resonance** defines the fundamental gesture and the decisions a game must make;
- **the standard configuration** provides simple, fully playable answers to those decisions;
- **a game designed with Resonance** can keep those answers or transform them when a world, genre, trope, or perspective has something particular to make the player feel.

Resonance defines what must be decided.
The standard configuration provides a default decision.
A Resonance game can keep or transform those decisions.

Resonance therefore does not try to move the complexity of a world into an ever more detailed technical model. It tries to preserve that complexity where it already has meaning: in the situations, relationships, beliefs, institutions, symbols, constraints, and consequences of the fiction.

The player is invited to look at the world rather than search for a rule to activate. The game designer is invited to decide what their game teaches players to notice, what it makes impossible and, when it genuinely matters, how a way of inhabiting the world transforms uncertainty itself.

In Resonance, the world does not merely decorate the mechanics.
It determines what matters — and can go as far as determining how uncertainty takes on meaning.